Official Rules

A Tavern Battle Card Game

Beat the DM. Grow THEIR tab, not yours.

3–6 PLAYERS • 15–25 MIN • AGES 16+

Overview

You and the table play WAR against the Drink Master (DM). Beat the DM to make your rivals drink; lose and the DM drinks you under the table. **Finish with the lowest Drink Tab to win.**

> **Drinking is optional.** The game plays the same with Shot Tokens and no drinks at all. The drinking add-on is only for adults of legal drinking age where you're playing; for everyone else, a "shot" can be soda, juice or water.

Components

Component	Qty
Player decks (one per suit)	6 × 25 cards
Drink Master (DM) deck	24 cards
Buzz-Kills for the DM deck	6
Suit Ability cards	6
Shot Tokens	1 supply
Shield Tokens (Mugs only)	3
Drink Tab score pad · Rulesheet	1 each

Each player deck: 18 number cards (2–10, two of each), 2 Jack of Beer, 2 Queen of Rum, 1 King of Wine, 1 Ace of Buzz, 1 Buzz-Kill.

The DM deck holds the same 24 ranked cards with no Buzz-Kill. Its Buzz-Kills are added at setup.

Card ranks, low to high: Buzz-Kill (0), 2–10, Jack, Queen, King, Ace.

Quick Reference

Card doesn't beat the DM	**+1 token**
Lowest card of the round	**+1 token**
Lose a Player vs Player War	**+2 tokens**
Lose a War vs the DM	**+1 token**
Win a War vs the DM	**–1 Drink Tab**
Eliminated	**+2 tokens**
4 Shot Tokens	**1 shot, +1 Drink Tab**

Double Down doubles your tokens and rewards that round. Lowest Drink Tab wins.

Setup

1. **Pick your suit.** Take a player deck and its Suit Ability card, face up in front of you. The Mugs player also takes the 3 Shield Tokens.
2. **Build the DM deck.** Shuffle the 24 DM cards with 1 Buzz-Kill per player (4 players = 4). Return the rest to the box. Place it face down in the center.
3. **Shuffle your deck,** let the player on your left cut it, and place it face down in front of you.
4. **Draw 4 cards.** Your hand returns to 4 after every round and every War.
5. **Set out the Shot Tokens** where everyone can reach them.
6. **Start the Drink Tab:** write each player's name on the score pad.
7. **Drinking add-on (optional, legal age only):** agree on what one "shot" is.

Playing a Round

1. **DM reveals** the top card of the DM deck. (Buzz-Kill? See Buzz-Kill.)
2. **Double Down** now if you want to (optional).
3. **Play** 1 card from your hand face down.
4. **Draw** back to 4 once everyone has played.
5. **Reveal** all played cards at once.
6. **Resolve** the round (below).
7. **Shots & elimination:** anyone at 4 Shot Tokens takes a shot; anyone who couldn't play is eliminated.

Discard all played cards, yours and the DM's, at the end of the round.

Resolving the Round

You're playing against the DM card **and** against each other.

1. **Buzz-Kills step out** of this round's results.
2. **Didn't beat the DM?** +1 Shot Token. Beat it and you take nothing.
3. **Lowest card** of all players: +1 more Shot Token.
4. **Matched the DM?** War against the DM.
5. **Tied another player?** War against each other, whether or not you beat the DM.
6. **Highest card that beats the DM** wins the round and uses its Suit Ability.

TURN OVER FOR WAR, BUZZ-KILL, DOUBLE DOWN & SUIT ABILITIES

How Ties Play Out

A player-vs-player tie never cancels the normal results; the War decides who carries them.

- **Both lost to the DM:** both take the DM token, then War. The loser also takes the War penalty.
- **Both beat the DM:** neither takes the DM token. The War loser takes the War penalty.
- **Tied on the lowest card:** the War loser also takes the lowest-card token.
- **Tied on the highest card:** the War winner uses their Suit Ability.

If the War ends in a draw, nobody carries the result: no lowest-card token and no Suit Ability that round.

War

Fought with cards from your hand, at most 2 rounds. After any War, draw back to 4.

PLAYER VS PLAYER

1. Each player plays 1 card face down, then all flip. Highest card wins.
2. **Tie?** Each plays a second card face down and flips.
3. **Tied again?** A draw: no winner, no loser, no penalty, no reward.

The loser takes **+2 Shot Tokens**. The winner takes nothing.

PLAYER VS DM

1. The DM places the top DM card face down. Each player in the War plays 1 card face down.
2. Flip every card, including the DM's. You only fight the DM card, not each other.
3. **Tie with the DM?** The DM draws a second card and you play a second card. Tied again: a dead game, no penalty and no reward.

Vs DM result	Effect
Win (beat the DM card)	**–1 Drink Tab**
Lose	**+1 Shot Token**
Draw	Nothing

A Buzz-Kill played in a War counts as 0.

Buzz-Kill

Your Buzz-Kill. Play it as your card: it counts as 0 and you sit out the round's results. After the round, **remove up to 2 Shot Tokens** or **reduce your Drink Tab by 1**. Then discard it.

The DM's Buzz-Kill. Every player **without** a Buzz-Kill in hand takes +1 Shot Token. Players **with** one discard it, take no token and draw back to 4. Discard the DM's Buzz-Kill and reveal the next DM card.

Double Down

Declare right after the DM reveals, before anyone plays. That round, **everything you gain or lose is doubled**, War included:

- Every Shot Token you take ×2 (a lost PvP War = +4).
- Win the round: **remove 2 Shot Tokens** or **–1 Drink Tab**.
- Win a War vs the DM: **–2 Drink Tab**.
- Suit Abilities are **never** doubled.

Suit Abilities

Triggers only when **you win the round and beat the DM.**

♥ **The Survivor**
Pass 1 of your Shot Tokens to any player, **or** reduce your Drink Tab by 1.

♦ **The Schemer**
Look at one player's hand and swap 1 card of your choice with them, **or** remove 1 Shot Token from yourself.

♠ **The Executioner**
Target player gains +2 Shot Tokens. Won with a face card? +1 more.

♣ **The Pressure Engine**
All other players gain +1 Shot Token. In 5–6 player games, one player of your choice gains +1 more.

The High Roller
Double your rewards this round as if you had declared Double Down, **or** target player gains +2 Shot Tokens.

The Tank
Gain 1 Shield Token (max 3). Each Shield cancels 1 Shot Token you would receive.

Shots & the Drink Tab

At **4 Shot Tokens**, take 1 shot, add 1 to your Drink Tab and return the 4 tokens. Shields are used automatically: each cancels 1 Shot Token you would receive.

Elimination

Can't play a card during the Play step (empty hand, empty deck)? You're eliminated: take **+2 Shot Tokens**. If that reaches 4, take your shot as normal.

Game End

How it ends	What happens
The DM deck runs out	Players beat the DM: everyone –2 Drink Tab.
Only one player is left	That player –1 Drink Tab.
Every player is eliminated	The DM wins: everyone takes 2 shots (+2 Drink Tab).

Either way, the lowest Drink Tab wins.

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